St. James's Place (SJP): interview deep dive

Prepared: 6 November 2026. **Purpose:** preparing for the SJP Wealth Management Programme video interview.

How to read the labels

- **PRIMARY**: taken from an SJP filing or RNS (Regulatory News Service, the stock exchange's official announcement feed), or from a regulator or company document. Most PRIMARY figures here come from SJP's FY2024 and FY2025 results releases, which I read directly.
- **REPORTED**: from reputable press or trade press, or a figure from a company filing that I only saw quoted second-hand.
- **UNVERIFIED**: from a single source, a low-quality source, or my own memory. Do not quote these in an interview without checking them.
- **[Interpretation]**: my own analysis rather than fact.
- **DON'T QUOTE**: sources disagree. Use the direction of travel, not the number.

What may have changed since today (6 Nov 2026):

- The share price, which moves daily.
- The ongoing-advice refund review. SJP expects to finish it during 2026.
- The FCA's planned rewrite of its advice rules.
- Measures from the 28 October 2026 Budget.
- SJP's Q4 update, due **28 January 2027** (REPORTED, from SJP's financial calendar), and FY2026 results, due around late February 2027.

Check all of these again the week before any live interview.

One-page cheat sheet

The role. Wealth Management Graduate Programme, London (Lombard Street), starting Sept 2027. It is a two-year **head-office** rotation supporting the Partners: data and insight, adviser and client experience, strategic projects, and the Wealth Management CEO Office. It includes the Level 4 Diploma in Regulated Financial Planning. It is **not** an adviser role.

SJP in one breath. The UK's largest advice business:

- **~£242bn** FUM (funds under management) and **1.06m** clients
- **~5,000** self-employed advisers called **Partners**
- **Restricted** advice: the advisers recommend SJP's own products and funds
- **Vertically integrated:** SJP owns the advice, the wrappers (ISA, pension, bond) and the funds, and appoints external managers to run the money
- Average client holds **~£226k** with SJP. It is **not** a private bank.

Key numbers

Measure	Figure
Gross inflows	2025 **£21.9bn**; H1 2026 £10.5bn
Net inflows	2025 **£6.2bn**; H1 2026 £2.7bn; Q3 2026 £0.57bn
Retention	**~95%**
Underlying cash result	2025 **£462m**
Dividend	**18p** a year (cut from 52.78p in 2022)
Shareholder payout	**70%** of profit from 2026

Fees since 26 Aug 2025

Charge	Rate
Initial advice	3% / 2% / 1% tiers, capped at £30k
Ongoing advice	**0.8%** a year
Product	0.27–0.35% a year
Fund	e.g. 0.52% a year

- That makes about **1.6–1.7% a year all-in**.
- **On £500k:** about **£7,950 a year**, plus £12,500 up front.
- The early withdrawal (exit) charge is **scrapped for new money**.

The controversy

- **Oct 2023:** the FT reports on exit fees and opaque charges.
- **Feb 2024:** a **£426m provision** (money set aside) to refund ongoing advice fees, charged since 2018, where SJP couldn't show the service was delivered.
    - The dividend was cut and the shares fell about 30%.
    - **No FCA fine.**
- **June 2026:** £110m of the provision is left. SJP expects to finish the review in 2026, and has been releasing the unused money to shareholders through buybacks.

Strategy and people

- **Strategy:** CEO **Mark FitzPatrick** (since Dec 2023) runs "Strengthen" (2024–26), then **"Amplify" (2027+)**, the year you'd join.
- **Other leaders:** CFO **Caroline Waddington**; Chair **Paul Manduca**.

Peers

- **Quilter:** the closest integrated rival, with about 9% net flows.
- **Rathbones:** a discretionary investment manager with outflows.
- **Evelyn:** now owned by NatWest.
- **Hargreaves Lansdown:** a self-directed (D2C) platform, now privately owned.
- **AJ Bell:** a low-cost D2C platform, with about 9% net flows.

The one insight to use. At ~95% retention, SJP loses about £11bn a year to withdrawals. Gross inflows are strong, but net inflows are the number to watch, especially as SJP enters Amplify.

1. The business model

What SJP actually is

SJP is the UK's largest wealth management business, measured by number of advisers and by money managed. It is listed on the London Stock Exchange (ticker STJ) and has its head office in Cirencester.

At 30 June 2026 it looked after **£240.8bn of funds under management** for **1,064,000 clients**, through **4,951 advisers** (all PRIMARY, H1 2026 results).

- **Funds under management (FUM):** the total value of client money a firm looks after.
- **What SJP is not:** it is not mainly a stock-picker, and it is not a bank. It is best understood as **a distribution and advice business that owns the products and funds its advisers recommend.**

The Partnership: self-employed advisers

SJP employs relatively few of the people who give the advice.

- **Who the advisers are:** most are **self-employed "Partners"**. They run their own advice businesses, often small practices with a few advisers and support staff, under the SJP brand.
- **Regulatory set-up:** legally, Partners are **appointed representatives** of SJP's regulated advice company. An appointed representative is a firm that is allowed to give regulated advice because a larger, FCA-authorised firm (the "principal") takes regulatory responsibility for it. So SJP is answerable to the FCA for its Partners' advice, but the Partners own their client relationships and business economics.
- **How Partners are paid:** from the advice charges clients pay. Partners can build up the value of their business over time and sell it. SJP also lends to Partners to fund practice purchases; it reports a provision against "business loans to Partners" (PRIMARY, FY2025 accounts).
- **New advisers:** SJP's **Academy** trains career-changers into advisers. More than 89% of people who complete the Academy are still with SJP three years later (PRIMARY, FY2024 release).
- **Why it matters [Interpretation]:** the Partners are entrepreneurs, so the model grows fast and the incentives to win clients are strong. The same incentives are where the conduct risks come from. The FCA holds SJP responsible for thousands of advisers whose day-to-day work it does not directly manage.

Note on headcount: SJP reports **4,934 advisers at end-2025** (PRIMARY). An industry survey (ISS Market Intelligence, reported by Professional Adviser, Feb 2026) puts it at **5,153**. The definitions differ, so use SJP's figure and say "around 5,000 advisers". I could not verify a current count of Partner *businesses* (as opposed to individual advisers), so **DON'T QUOTE** a figure for that.

"Restricted" versus "independent" advice

These are FCA labels.

- **Independent advice** must be based on a "comprehensive and fair analysis of the relevant market" and be "unbiased and unrestricted". An independent financial adviser (IFA) can in principle recommend any suitable product from any provider.
- **Restricted advice** is everything else. The adviser recommends from a limited range of products or providers.
- **Where SJP sits:** SJP advisers are restricted. They mostly recommend SJP's own wrappers and SJP's own funds.
- **The criticism:** the client never sees a whole-of-market comparison.

- **SJP's answer:** it researches the market for you and picks and monitors the fund managers on your behalf.

"Restricted" is legal and common; Quilter's own advisers are also restricted. It does mean the adviser has a structural conflict of interest, which has to be managed rather than eliminated.

Vertical integration: advice, product, platform and funds under one roof

Vertical integration means one group owns several stages of the value chain that a client pays for. A typical UK client with an IFA pays four separate parties:

Layer	What it is	Typical independent route	SJP route
Advice	Financial planning, recommending what to do	An IFA firm	SJP Partner (appointed representative of SJP)
Wrapper / product	The tax "container": ISA, pension (SIPP), investment bond, unit trust	Provider or platform	SJP's own life company (bonds, pensions) and SJP's unit trust company (ISAs, unit trusts)
Platform / administration	Holds the assets, does the dealing and paperwork	A platform such as Transact or Quilter	SJP's own proposition. The back-office work is outsourced to a third-party administrator that SJP pays a "policy servicing tariff" (PRIMARY)
Fund management	Investing the money	Any fund house	SJP's own funds (e.g. the **Polaris** range, £94bn at end-2025, PRIMARY). SJP's investment team chooses and oversees **external fund managers** to run the money, a "manager of managers" model (PRIMARY: "investment management fees paid to external fund managers")

[Interpretation] Owning every layer lets SJP:

1. Capture a margin at each layer.
2. Make the experience seamless for the adviser.
3. Keep clients "sticky", because moving means unwinding several products at once.

The cost is that it is hard for clients to compare prices, and that comparability is exactly what regulators have pushed on.

Who the typical client is and what they're worth

- **Average FUM per client:** £240.8bn ÷ 1.064m clients ≈ **£226,000** (derived from PRIMARY figures). This is a mean, so the median client is probably smaller.
- **[Interpretation]** The core client is "mass affluent" to "high net worth" (HNW):
  - professionals, business owners and pre-retirees or retirees;
  - typically £100k to a few £m of investable assets;
  - who want someone to handle pensions, ISAs, inheritance tax planning, protection and retirement income for them.
- **Compared with an ultra-high-net-worth (UHNW) private bank:** UHNW is conventionally US$30m+ of net worth. Private banks such as Coutts, JP Morgan Private Bank and UBS serve fewer, much wealthier clients. They offer lending, complex structuring, bespoke portfolios, alternatives and family-office services, at fees in percentage terms often lower than SJP's because the pots are so large.

- **SJP's model is the opposite:** high volume, relationship-driven, advice-first, standardised in-house fund range. Saying "SJP is a private bank" in an interview would be a mistake (see the end).

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2. How it makes money

The current charging structure (in force since 26 August 2025)

All PRIMARY, from SJP's announcement of the new charges and its FY2025 results.

1. Initial advice charge (one-off, on new money):

- 3% on the first £250,000
- 2% on the next £250,000
- 1% above £500,000
- Capped at **£30,000** (REPORTED, per SJP charges pages as quoted by MoneyWeek and others)

2. Ongoing advice charge: 0.80% a year of the investment's value. Under the old structure it was 0.5% (REPORTED).

3. Ongoing product charge (the wrapper and platform layer), tiered across the client's whole SJP portfolio:

Portfolio value	Investment bonds and pensions	ISAs and unit trusts
First £500k	0.35%	0.27%
Next £500k	0.32%	0.24%
Next £1m	0.29%	0.21%
Next £1m	0.27%	0.19%
Over £3m	0.25%	0.17%

4. Fund charge: this varies by fund. For **Polaris 3**, a commonly used mid-risk fund, it is **0.52%**. SJP gives the total ongoing cost for that fund as **1.59% (ISA)** or **1.67% (pension)** (REPORTED, from SJP's charges material as quoted in the press; single example, so check the current figure on sjp.co.uk).

5. Early withdrawal charge (EWC): abolished for new investments. It still applies to bonds and pensions taken out before the change (see section 3).

Charges not covered here: transaction costs inside funds, discretionary fund management (DFM, where a manager runs a bespoke portfolio for you), and other services.

Worked example: a client investing £500,000 into an ISA/unit trust in Polaris 3

Charge	Calculation	£ per year
Initial advice (year 1 only)	3% × £250k + 2% × £250k	**£12,500** (2.5%)
Ongoing advice	0.80% × £500k	£4,000
Product (ISA/unit trust tier 1)	0.27% × £500k	£1,350
Fund (Polaris 3)	0.52% × £500k	£2,600
Ongoing total	**1.59%**	**£7,950 a year**
Year 1 all-in		**£20,450** (4.1%)

- **Same money in a pension or bond:** the product charge is 0.35%, so the ongoing total is 1.67%, or **£8,350 a year**.
- **Over 10 years:** at a flat £500k value, that's about £12.5k up front plus about £79.5k of ongoing charges, roughly **£92k**. In reality the pot grows and the charges grow with it, because they are percentages.

Who captures each layer

Layer	Who mainly receives it	Status
Initial advice charge	Mostly the **Partner**. SJP says initial advice charges "broadly offset new business-related expenses", which include "payments to Partners", so SJP itself makes roughly **zero** on new business under the new structure and expects this to continue.	PRIMARY
Ongoing advice charge (0.8%)	Mostly the **Partner**. Trade press reports that under the new structure SJP retains a share of the recurring advice fee for the first time. The split is not public.	REPORTED (split UNVERIFIED)
Product charge	**SJP** (the product provider), which pays the third-party administrator out of it	PRIMARY (structure)
Fund charge	Split between **SJP** (its fund management margin) and the **external fund managers** it hires	PRIMARY (structure)

- **What SJP keeps overall:** SJP reports a **net income from FUM margin** (what it keeps after paying Partners, external managers and the administrator).
  - **Old structure: 0.54% to 0.56%** of mature FUM.
  - **New structure: 0.43% to 0.45%** (PRIMARY, FY2025).
- **Rough split on the £500k example [Interpretation]:**
  - SJP keeps roughly **£2,150 to £2,250 a year**.
  - The Partner gets most of the **£4,000** advice fee.
  - External fund managers and the administrator take the rest, roughly £1,500 to £1,800.
  - This is an estimate built on SJP's margin guidance. SJP does not publish a per-client split.
- **2026 guidance:** SJP moved to a new "adjusted IFRS" reporting basis in 2026. On that basis its guidance is **47 to 49 basis points of average FUM**, with an expected rise of about 3 bps a year to 2031 (REPORTED, from H1 2026 results coverage). This is **a different basis** from the 0.43–0.45% figure, so don't compare the two numbers directly. A basis point (bp) is 0.01%.

What changed in the fee restructure, when, and why

The old structure (pre-26 August 2025), simplified (REPORTED, plus PRIMARY on gestation):

- **Initial charges** of up to about 4.5% on new investments. On bonds and pensions there was no explicit up-front fee. Instead the cost was recovered over time.
- **"Gestation"** (PRIMARY): for the **first six years** after a bond or pension investment, SJP earned little or no ongoing product margin. That money only became profitable "mature FUM" in year 7. SJP still had **£52.9bn of FUM in gestation at end-2025** (PRIMARY), which stays on the old terms until it matures.
- **The early withdrawal charge (EWC):** to make sure SJP recovered its up-front costs, a client leaving within six years paid an exit charge. It started at **6% in year one and fell by 1 percentage point a year to zero after year six** (REPORTED, Trustnet, Telegraph, MoneyHelpDesk).
- **Charges bundled together:** it was hard for a client to see what they were paying for advice versus the product versus the fund.

The new structure (from 26 August 2025, PRIMARY):

- Charges are **unbundled**. Advice, product and fund charges are shown separately, and all ongoing charges apply **from day one**.
- **No EWC** on new money.
- **Tiered** initial and product charges, so large clients pay less in percentage terms.
- **Fund charges reduced:** SJP says almost 95% of its funds with an IA peer group comparison rank below average on cost (PRIMARY, SJP's claim). The IA is the Investment Association, the UK fund industry's trade body.
- **Cost to implement: £119.4m post-tax** in total (PRIMARY).

Timeline:

Date	Event
Oct 2023	The FT reports regulatory pressure over "opaque and expensive charges" and exit penalties; shares fall ~15% that day (REPORTED). SJP then announces it will scrap EWCs on new business and overhaul charges.
Dec 2023	Mark FitzPatrick (ex-Prudential) becomes CEO, succeeding Andrew Croft (REPORTED).
Jul 2024	FitzPatrick sets out the "Strengthen" strategy (2024–26) to make SJP "simpler, more efficient, and more transparent", alongside a ~£100m cost-reduction programme (PRIMARY).
26 Aug 2025	The new structure goes live (PRIMARY).

Why the change happened:

- **(a) Consumer Duty and its "fair value" test**, which made opaque, back-loaded charges hard to defend (see section 3).
- **(b) Press and regulator scrutiny.**
- **(c) Comparability:** SJP itself calls it the "simple, comparable charging structure".
- **[Interpretation]** It was also commercially necessary. A business whose biggest cost to clients was hidden in exit fees was exposed to both regulatory and reputational risk.

The trade-off for shareholders (PRIMARY):

- **Short term:** lower profit, because margins on new and mature business both fell. SJP calls this a "dip in profitability" in 2025–26.
- **Medium term:** faster profit growth, because new business is profitable from day one and the £52.9bn gestation book matures with "no additional associated expenses".
- **Ambition:** SJP aims to **double the Underlying cash result between 2023 and 2030** (PRIMARY).

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3. The difficult part

a) The early withdrawal charge (EWC)

What it was: the charge of up to 6% (falling 1 point a year) described in section 2.

Why it was criticised (REPORTED):

- **It locked clients in.** A client unhappy with their adviser, or with poor fund performance, faced a penalty of thousands of pounds to leave. That blunts competition, because the threat of losing

clients is what normally disciplines a provider.

- **It hid the real cost of advice.** Bonds and pensions had no visible up-front fee, so clients could believe advice was "free" when the cost was being recovered through ongoing charges and the exit fee.
- **It looked out of line with peers.** Most of the advised market had moved to transparent, unbundled fees after the 2013 **Retail Distribution Review (RDR)**, which banned commission on new investment advice. Critics argued SJP's bundled model kept a pre-RDR economic shape. **[Interpretation]**: SJP's structure was compliant, so this is a "spirit, not letter" criticism.
- **The Ombudsman has generally upheld the charge.** The **Financial Ombudsman Service (FOS)** is the free, independent body that settles consumer complaints against financial firms. It has generally upheld the EWC where it was clearly disclosed (REPORTED, FOS decisions). The legal case was weaker than the reputational one.

Status: scrapped for new investments from 26 August 2025. **Still outstanding:** pre-August-2025 bond and pension money remains subject to the EWC until it runs off, which takes up to six years, so until around 2031 (PRIMARY: existing clients move to the new charges "once they come to the end of their early withdrawal charge period").

b) The £426m provision (February 2024)

What happened (PRIMARY and REPORTED):

- **28 February 2024, FY2023 results:** SJP made a **£426m pre-tax provision**. A provision is money set aside in the accounts for a likely future cost.
- **What it was for:** to refund clients who had paid **ongoing advice charges** (the annual fee for an annual review and ongoing service) **since the start of 2018** where SJP could not show sufficient evidence the service had actually been delivered.
- **Why:** SJP said it followed a **significant rise in complaints** in late 2023, many driven by press coverage and **claims management companies** (firms that solicit and file complaints on consumers' behalf for a fee).
- **Same day:**
  - The dividend was cut from **52.78p (2022) to 23.83p (2023)** (REPORTED; the 23.83p is PRIMARY).
  - The post-tax cash result fell sharply.
  - SJP warned of lower future payouts.
  - The shares fell **around 30%** to their lowest level in more than a decade (REPORTED).
- **Formal name:** SJP now calls it the **Ongoing Service Evidence (OSE)** review.
- **Recovering costs from Partners:** SJP has said it will recover part of the cost from Partners depending on circumstances (REPORTED).

How the provision has moved (PRIMARY, FY2025 accounts note 9, and H1 2026):

Point	Balance	Movement
Recognised (1 Jan 2024)	£426.0m	
31 Dec 2024	£425.1m	£18.5m used, plus discounting adjustment
31 Dec 2025	£272.3m	£52.5m used; **£109.5m released** (no longer needed)
30 Jun 2026	**£110.0m**	**£110.4m further released** (REPORTED from H1 2026 coverage; Money Marketing headline "SJP cuts ongoing-advice provision to £110m")

- **Why the releases happened:** (a) a **revised redress methodology** aligned to **new FCA industry guidance on ongoing advice issued in February 2025**, and (b) experience from

actually doing the reviews (PRIMARY).

- **Where the released money goes:** SJP is returning released money to shareholders through buybacks:
  - £63.4m (H1 2025)
  - £18.7m (FY2025)
  - £82.8m (H1 2026)
  - (all PRIMARY)
- **Scale of the review:** 77 million documents have been sourced for it (REPORTED).
- **[Interpretation]** Of the original £426m, only around £70m had actually been used by end-2025. Roughly £220m was released in 2025 and H1 2026 combined. The original estimate now looks substantially too high, but the final cost won't be known until the review completes.

DON'T QUOTE: some press cite "£430m" or "£430.6m" for the redress bill. SJP's own accounts say £426.0m. Use **£426m**.

c) Consumer Duty and what the FCA actually required

- **What Consumer Duty is:** an FCA rule set (Principle 12 plus detailed rules). It applied to products on sale from **31 July 2023** and to closed or legacy products from **31 July 2024**. Firms must deliver **good outcomes** for retail customers across four areas:
  1. products and services;
  2. **price and value** (is the price reasonable for what the customer gets?);
  3. consumer understanding;
  4. consumer support.
- **Why it raised the bar:** the old standard was "was it disclosed?". The new one is "is it fair value, and can you prove it?". That is why both SJP's bundled charges and charging for unevidenced annual reviews became exposed.
- **What the FCA did (REPORTED):** in early 2024 the FCA wrote to around 20 of the largest advice firms asking whether clients paying ongoing advice fees were receiving the service. Sources say "20" or "22". It later published findings and, in **February 2025, industry guidance on ongoing advice services**, which SJP used to set its refund method (PRIMARY: SJP Annual Report 2025).
- **What I did *not* find:** any **FCA enforcement action, fine or formally imposed redress scheme against SJP**. SJP's review is presented as **firm-led**, carried out under Consumer Duty and in the context of FCA supervision.
  - **Careful phrasing:** say "SJP launched a review and provision after complaints rose and the FCA scrutinised the industry". **Don't** say "the FCA fined SJP" or "the FCA ordered SJP to repay £426m".
  - Check the FCA website before stating anything stronger.
- **It's industry-wide, not just SJP (REPORTED):**
  - Quilter had a "skilled person" appointed (an independent reviewer the FCA can require a firm to appoint) to assess ongoing advice in its network.
  - Rathbones has flagged about £60m of FCA-related remediation costs.

d) What's resolved and what's outstanding

Resolved:

- The new charging structure is live, and EWCs are gone for new business.
- Most of the provision has been used or released.
- SJP expects the OSE review to complete **during 2026** (PRIMARY).
- The dividend policy has been reset, and returns are rising again (see section 4).

Outstanding:

1. **Final completion of the OSE review** and its final cost; £110m remained at June 2026.
2. **Legacy EWC book:** pre-Aug-2025 bonds and pensions still carry exit charges until they run off, up to 2031.
3. **Complaints:** FOS complaints about SJP rose sharply, to **1,426 in H1 2025** against 485 in H1 2024 (REPORTED, International Adviser/FOS data). Claims management firms remain active. **DON'T QUOTE** other complaint totals; sources mix complaints made to SJP with complaints to FOS.
4. **Ongoing Consumer Duty fair-value scrutiny:** this is continuous, not a one-off test.
5. **FCA's planned simplification of advice rules,** including how often ongoing reviews must happen. A consultation was reported in spring 2026 with final rules expected late 2026 or early 2027 (UNVERIFIED reference number; check the FCA site).

The strongest criticism

> SJP built a high-cost, vertically integrated model whose economics depended on clients not being able to see, compare, or easily escape its charges. Exit penalties locked people in, bundled fees disguised the price of advice, and an incentive structure rewarding asset-gathering produced a culture where thousands of clients paid for annual reviews they didn't get. SJP reformed only after press exposure, a new regulatory regime (Consumer Duty), and a collapse in its share price forced it to. Even now, a ~1.6–1.7% all-in annual cost (plus up-front fees) is expensive against platforms, robo-advisers and lower-cost advisers. The advice is restricted to SJP's own products, so the client never sees what they could have had elsewhere. The provision releases are going to shareholders, and the legacy exit-fee book will run until around 2031.

The strongest defence

> SJP's structure was compliant and disclosed; the FOS has generally upheld the EWC. What clients buy is a long-term relationship and holistic planning (pensions, IHT, protection, retirement income), not a fund. Behaviour shows they value it: FUM retention stayed around 95% straight through the worst of the crisis, and gross inflows *rose* 19% in 2025 to £21.9bn. When problems surfaced SJP acted: it provisioned conservatively, the provision turned out larger than needed, and it scrapped EWCs. It also rebuilt its pricing into one of the clearest unbundled tariffs in the market, with tiering that cuts costs for larger clients and fund charges SJP says are below the peer average. Ongoing-advice evidence problems have surfaced at Quilter, Rathbones and others, so this was an industry issue that SJP, as the biggest firm, confronted first and at the largest scale. And the UK has a large "advice gap": far more people need advice than receive it.

[Interpretation] Both are partly true. The criticism is strongest on *history*: the lock-in and opacity were real, and reform was reactive. The defence is strongest on *client behaviour since*, through retention and gross inflows.

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4. The numbers

Flows, FUM and retention

Definitions:

- **Gross inflows:** new money clients invest.
- **Net inflows:** gross inflows minus money withdrawn (surrenders, transfers out, income taken).
- **Retention:** the share of FUM that did *not* leave during the period, annualised.

Year	Gross inflows	Net inflows	Net as % of opening FUM	Retention	Closing FUM	Advisers
2021	n/a	£11.0bn			£154.0bn	
2022	n/a	£9.8bn			£148.4bn	
2023	£15.4bn	£5.1bn	3.5%	95.3%	£168.2bn	
2024	£18.4bn	£4.3bn	2.6%	94.5%	£190.2bn	4,920
2025	£21.9bn	£6.2bn	3.2%	94.9%	£220.0bn	4,934
H1 2026	£10.5bn	£2.7bn	2.5% annualised	95.4%	£240.8bn	4,951
Q3 2026 (quarter)	£5.15bn	£0.57bn		95.1% (YTD)	£242.4bn	

Sources: 2021–2025 PRIMARY (FY2024 and FY2025 results); H1 2026 PRIMARY (SJP H1 2026 page); Q3 2026 REPORTED (press coverage of the 29 Oct 2026 RNS).

Why the gap between gross and net matters [Interpretation, built on PRIMARY data]:

- **What 95% retention means:** at ~95% retention, about 5% of FUM walks out every year, which is **£11bn+ a year** at today's size. SJP has to raise about £11bn of new money just to stand still.
- **The 2025 picture:** in 2025, £21.9bn gross became only £6.2bn net, so roughly **70% of gross inflows were offset by outflows**.
- **Q3 2026:** net inflows fell to £0.57bn because surrenders rose (£3.08bn in the quarter against £2.65bn a year earlier, REPORTED). SJP blamed a strong comparison quarter, boosted by clients investing ahead of the charging change.
- **SJP's defence:** much of the outflow is natural. An older client base draws income in retirement, and clients withdrew tax-free cash ahead of Budget speculation in late 2025 (PRIMARY: SJP said this hit late-2025 retention).
- **The critics' point:** a 2.5–3% net flow rate is low for a firm with ~5,000 advisers when platforms are growing at ~9%+ (see section 5).
- **Where FUM growth comes from: mostly markets, not flows.** In 2025, investment returns added ~£23.6bn (12% of opening FUM) against £6.2bn of net inflows (PRIMARY). In H1 2026, returns added £18.1bn against £2.7bn net inflows (PRIMARY).

Profit, revenue and margin

SJP's IFRS "revenue" line is distorted by policyholder investment returns and policyholder tax, so analysts focus on the following instead (all PRIMARY):

Metric	2023	2024	2025
Net income from FUM	n/a	£683.6m	£725.2m
Underlying cash result (post-tax)	£392.4m	£447.2m	£462.3m
IFRS profit after tax	loss (REPORTED: −£9.9m)	£398.4m	£531.4m
Controllable expenses	n/a	£291.7m	£305.8m

- **Underlying cash result:** SJP's main profit measure. It strips out non-cash accounting items and one-offs such as the provision. From 2026 SJP calls it **"adjusted IFRS profit after tax"**.

- **Margin (PRIMARY):** net income from FUM was **0.54–0.56%** of mature FUM under the old structure and **0.43–0.45%** under the new one. For 2026 SJP guides **47–49 bps** on its new reporting basis (REPORTED). This is not comparable with the earlier figures (see section 2).
- **H1 2026:**
  - Adjusted profit before tax **£278.4m**, against £307.0m a year earlier, **down 9%**. SJP said this was expected because of the new charges (PRIMARY).
  - It still beat analyst consensus comfortably. Coverage cites consensus of around £194m (REPORTED; single source for the consensus figure).
  - "Profit from inflows" collapsed from £127.0m to £17.7m, as expected, because initial charges no longer generate margin (REPORTED).
- **Cost programme:** a target of about **£100m a year** of savings by 2027, with about half reinvested (PRIMARY, with the reinvestment detail REPORTED).

Shareholder returns

Year	Dividend per share	Notes
2022	52.78p	REPORTED
2023	23.83p	**Cut** with the provision (PRIMARY)
2024	18.00p	Payout reset to 50% of the Underlying cash result (PRIMARY)
2025	18.00p	Total shareholder returns £313.3m including OSE-release buybacks (PRIMARY)
2026 interim	6.00p	Plus £45.3m ordinary buyback and £82.8m OSE-release buyback (PRIMARY)

- **New policy from FY2026:** return **70% of the Underlying cash result**, with dividends at least 40% of that total and the rest via buybacks (PRIMARY). A **buyback** is the company purchasing its own shares, which returns cash to shareholders and raises earnings per share.
- **[Interpretation]** The dividend *per share* has been flat since the cut, while total payouts have risen through buybacks. Say "returns are being rebuilt, increasingly through buybacks". Don't say "the dividend has recovered".

Share price: the last three years (Nov 2023 – Nov 2026)

Exact levels vary by data provider. Use these as approximate landmarks and **check a live quote**.

When	What happened	Rough level / move	Label
Oct 2023	FT reports on fees and exit charges; SJP announces it will scrap EWCs	~−15% on the day	REPORTED
28 Feb 2024	£426m provision, dividend cut	~−30% intraday; decade low	REPORTED
Apr 2024	Bottom; drops out of the FTSE 100	~410–420p	REPORTED
H2 2024 – 2025	Recovery: strategy reset, strong gross inflows, provision releases, cost programme	~720p (Sep 2024) → ~1,250p (Sep 2025) → ~1,370p (Dec 2025)	REPORTED
Early 2026	52-week high	~1,575p (date conflicts between sources)	REPORTED

When	What happened	Rough level / move	Label
10–11 Feb 2026	**"AI scare":** US firm Altruist launched an AI tax-planning tool; investors feared AI would erode advice fees. SJP fell most among UK wealth managers. Chair Paul Manduca called it "almost certainly an overreaction"	Fall of about 11–13% (**DON'T QUOTE** an exact figure; sources disagree)	REPORTED
Jul 2026	New 52-week lows after analyst downgrades citing AI risk	~1,040p	REPORTED (single-source detail)
29 Oct 2026	Q3 update: weak net inflows	Down as much as ~5.6–5.7% intraday	REPORTED
6 Nov 2026	Today	~1,137p	UNVERIFIED (single quote page)

[Interpretation] Over three years the shares have roughly **tripled from the April 2024 low**, but they are down around a quarter from the early-2026 peak. The market moved from pricing an existential conduct crisis (2024), to a successful turnaround (2025), to worrying about a structural threat (AI, cheaper models and slowing net flows) in 2026.

5. Competitive position

Firm	What it is	Scale (latest)	Flows	Model vs SJP
SJP	Restricted advice + own wrappers + own (externally sub-advised) funds	£242.4bn FUM (Sep 2026, REPORTED); ~5,000 advisers	~2.5% annualised net (H1 2026, PRIMARY)	The benchmark for vertical integration
Quilter	Also vertically integrated: a platform used by thousands of *independent* advisers, its own restricted advice network (Quilter Financial Planning) and a DFM arm (Quilter Cheviot)	£157.4bn assets under management and administration (AuMA), H1 2026 (REPORTED)	Record core net inflows £6.0bn in H1 2026, ~9% of opening AuMA annualised (REPORTED)	**Closest peer.** It wins flows from IFAs via its platform as well as its own advisers. Adviser count **DON'T QUOTE** (sources give ~1,450–1,600). Also faced an FCA-driven skilled-person review of ongoing advice
Rathbones	Discretionary investment manager ("wealth manager" in the traditional sense): manages portfolios for wealthier clients, often referred by IFAs; some financial planning. Merged with Investec Wealth & Investment (Sept 2023)	£120.7bn funds under management and administration (FUMA), Jun 2026 (REPORTED)	H1 2026 net outflows ~£0.9bn, mostly asset management (REPORTED)	Investment-led, not advice-led; higher average client wealth; struggling for organic growth; FCA remediation (~£60m flagged, REPORTED)

Firm	What it is	Scale (latest)	Flows	Model vs SJP
Evelyn Partners	Integrated advice and discretionary investment manager	Bought by **NatWest** for ~£2.7bn enterprise value; agreed Feb 2026, completed ~30 June 2026. Combined NatWest/Evelyn AuMA ~£127bn (REPORTED)	n/a	Shows banks buying advice and wealth distribution. A bank-backed integrated rival is a new competitive threat
Hargreaves Lansdown (HL)	Direct-to-consumer (D2C) platform: clients pick investments themselves, with limited advice	Taken private by CVC, Nordic Capital and ADIA for ~£5.4bn (1,140p/share); completed **25 March 2025** (REPORTED)	n/a (no longer reports publicly)	Serves self-directed investors at a fraction of SJP's cost. Reported fee cut in 2026 (UNVERIFIED)
AJ Bell	D2C and adviser platform, low cost	£126.0bn platform assets under administration (AUA), 796,000 customers (FY to Sep 2026, PRIMARY trading update)	£9.7bn net inflows, ~9% of opening AUA (PRIMARY)	Growing fastest among listed UK peers; competes for the younger, self-directed end of the market

What is SJP's actual advantage? [Interpretation]

1. **Distribution scale.** About 5,000 advisers is the biggest face-to-face advice force in the UK, more than double the nearest restricted network. Clients typically come by **referral** from existing clients and professional contacts, which is cheap and trusted.
2. **Relationship stickiness.** About 95% retention through a conduct crisis and a share-price collapse is strong evidence that clients are loyal to *their adviser*.
3. **Adviser pipeline and economics.** The Academy manufactures new advisers, and Partners can build and sell valuable businesses. That attracts entrepreneurial advisers and keeps them. The CEO has cited partner retention of about 90% (REPORTED, Citywire via secondary).
4. **Brand and scale economics** in technology, investment oversight, compliance and marketing that a small IFA can't match.

Is it durable? [Interpretation]

- **The distribution and relationship advantage is durable.** Human advice for complex life events (retirement, inheritance, selling a business) is hard to commoditise, and the UK advice gap is large.
- **The pricing advantage is not.** Historically SJP earned above-market margins partly because pricing was opaque. Full transparency removes that, which is why margins have been reset down. The moat is now **the advisers, not the products**.
- **The main long-term risk is adviser defection.** If top Partners can earn more as independents (taking clients to cheaper platforms), the integrated model's weakest link is its strongest asset.

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6. The structural question: does advice-led vertical integration survive full fee transparency?

Bull case

1. **Clients stayed when the price became visible.** After the charging change (Aug 2025), H1 2026 gross inflows held at £10.5bn and retention *rose* to 95.4% (PRIMARY). The fee shock did not

trigger an exodus.

2. **Demand for advice is structural.** Several things push more people toward advice:
    - an ageing population;
    - pension freedoms, which mean retirees must manage drawdown themselves;
    - frozen tax thresholds;
    - **pensions coming into inheritance tax from April 2027** (REPORTED; announced in the October 2024 Budget).

    SJP calls advice "under-penetrated in the UK" (PRIMARY).

3. **A visible earnings recovery.** £52.9bn of gestation FUM matures into full margin over six years with no extra cost (PRIMARY). New business is profitable from day one. The £100m cost programme lands by 2027. Management expects "sharply accelerating earnings from 2027" (REPORTED) and targets doubling the 2023 Underlying cash result by 2030 (PRIMARY).

4. **Transparent pricing is now defensible.** At ~1.6–1.7% all-in for a full advice, wrapper and fund package, SJP is within the range of the advised market. Tiering makes it more competitive for larger clients, its core.

5. **Integration helps with Consumer Duty.** One firm controlling advice, product and fund can evidence outcomes end to end, which is harder in a fragmented chain.

Bear case

1. **Net flows are weak relative to scale.** A ~2.5% annualised net flow rate (H1 2026) and £0.57bn in Q3 2026, against ~9% at Quilter and AJ Bell (PRIMARY and REPORTED), suggests SJP is struggling to grow its share. FUM growth has been mostly market-driven.
2. **Transparency squeezes margins.** SJP's net margin on mature FUM fell from 0.54–0.56% to 0.43–0.45% (PRIMARY). Once clients can compare, the fund and product layers face constant price pressure from passive funds and platforms. SJP's own launch of a cheaper Polaris Multi-Index range (passive-based, >£1bn FUM, PRIMARY) is arguably an admission of this.
3. **Disruption at the lower end.** The FCA's **targeted support** regime (live **6 April 2026**, REPORTED) lets firms give semi-personalised suggestions without full advice. AI tools may automate the planning tasks advisers charge for. The Feb 2026 sell-off shows investors take this seriously.
4. **Conduct and complaints tail.** The legacy EWC book runs to ~2031. FOS complaints rose sharply in 2024–25. Consumer Duty fair-value tests are ongoing. The restricted model is a permanent conflict the FCA will keep scrutinising.
5. **Adviser economics.** Changes to how Partners are paid, with SJP now taking a share of the recurring advice fee (REPORTED), could make independence or rival networks more attractive to the best advisers.

Which is more convincing? [Interpretation: my view]

I find the bull case **more convincing on survival** and the bear case **more convincing on returns**.

- **The evidence that matters most is client behaviour after transparency arrived.** Retention around 95% and flat gross inflows through 2025–26 suggest clients buy the adviser relationship, not the product wrapper. So the integrated, advice-led model survives transparency.
- **It survives as a lower-margin, volume-driven business,** where profit growth depends on maturing legacy FUM, cost cuts and keeping advisers, not on pricing power.
- **The real test is 2027–28,** SJP's "Amplify" phase. Can it lift net flows from ~2.5–3% toward 4–5% of FUM with transparent prices, while holding margin guidance and stopping its best advisers

from leaving?

- **The single metric to watch is net inflows as a % of opening FUM.** If that keeps falling while competitors grow, the bear case wins.

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7. What's changed in the last 12 months (Nov 2025 – Nov 2026)

Date	Development	Label
Late 2025	Pre-Budget speculation about pension tax-free cash triggered extra withdrawals, which hit retention	PRIMARY
10–11 Feb 2026	AI-driven sell-off across UK wealth managers; SJP hit hardest	REPORTED
Feb 2026	NatWest agrees to buy Evelyn Partners (~£2.7bn); completed ~30 June 2026	REPORTED
25 Feb 2026	FY2025 results: record FUM £220bn, gross inflows +19%, Underlying cash result +3%. **Payout raised to 70%** a year earlier than planned. OSE review to complete in 2026	PRIMARY
Mar 2026	Evelyn Bourke joins the SJP board	PRIMARY
6 Apr 2026	FCA **targeted support** regime goes live (Advice Guidance Boundary Review)	REPORTED
Spring 2026	FCA consults on simplifying investment advice rules, including review frequency; final rules expected late 2026 or early 2027	UNVERIFIED (check FCA)
29 Jul 2026	H1 2026: record £240.8bn FUM, net inflows down to £2.7bn, adjusted PBT −9% but well ahead of consensus; **£110.4m provision release**, £110m remaining; £128m of buybacks	PRIMARY / REPORTED
Jul 2026	Rathbones reports H1 net outflows; Quilter reports record flows	REPORTED
Sep 2026	Justin Onuekwusi confirmed as CEO, Investments (after acting since January, replacing Tom Beal)	REPORTED
28 Oct 2026	Autumn Budget. SJP's own commentary names **John Healey** as Chancellor, which implies a change from Rachel Reeves. Measures include: triple lock replaced by a "double lock" from 2030; planned cash ISA cut to £12k reversed; savings and property income tax +2 points from April 2027; Business Asset Disposal Relief lifetime limit halved to £500k	UNVERIFIED (single SJP-authored source; **check GOV.UK before mentioning**)
29 Oct 2026	Q3 update: net inflows £0.57bn (vs £1.76bn), record £242.4bn FUM; shares down as much as ~5.6–5.7% intraday	REPORTED
Ongoing	Top leadership unchanged: **Mark FitzPatrick** (CEO), **Caroline Waddington** (CFO), **Paul Manduca** (Chair) (PRIMARY, Annual Report 2025)	PRIMARY
Coming up	Q4 update **28 Jan 2027**; FY2026 results ~Feb 2027; **"Amplify"** strategy phase from 2027; pensions in IHT from **April 2027**	REPORTED

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8. The role itself: Wealth Management Graduate Programme (London, Lombard Street, Sept 2027)

What this job actually is (read this first)

This is not an adviser role. You won't be a Partner and you won't join the Academy. You'll sit in SJP's **head-office Wealth Management function**: the part of SJP that supports the Partners and their clients. For two years you'll rotate through its teams, then stay permanently in the division. In practice that means:

- **Proposition and services:** what Partners can offer clients, and how.
- **Adviser support, technology and tools:** SJP is trialling AI tools to cut Partners' admin (PRIMARY, FY2024 and FY2025 releases).
- **Data and insight:** analysing flows, retention, adviser productivity and client outcomes.
- **Strategic projects,** including time in the **Wealth Management Chief Executive Office**, the team that runs the division's strategy and priorities.

The Level 4 Diploma in Regulated Financial Planning (usually taken through the CII as the "DipPFS") is the minimum qualification the FCA requires to give retail investment advice. You'll get the adviser's technical knowledge (tax, pensions, investments, regulation) without being an adviser. [Interpretation] That's a real asset: you'd be a head-office person who understands the advice process from the inside, and later moving to advise would remain possible. Don't present the role as a back door to becoming an adviser, though. They want people who will build a career in the division.

How the research maps to the job description

JD says	What it means at SJP right now	What to show them
"Support our network of financial advisers (Partners) and more than one million clients"	The Partnership is SJP's core asset (section 5). Partner retention and productivity are what drive net flows.	That you understand the Partners are self-employed businesses and SJP's internal "customers", not employees.
"Analyse data and produce insights to support business decision-making"	The numbers that matter: net inflows as a % of FUM, retention (~95%), gross vs net gap, adviser productivity, complaint volumes (section 4).	That you'd look at the *gap* between gross and net inflows, not just headline FUM.
"Contribute to projects that enhance the adviser and client experience"	Post-charging-change bedding-in; AI and admin tools for Partners; Polaris Multi-Index; evidencing ongoing service under Consumer Duty (sections 2–3).	A concrete example, e.g. "making it easy for Partners to *evidence* ongoing reviews, which is the lesson of the OSE review".
"Support strategic initiatives across the Wealth Management function" / CEO Office	Moving from "Strengthen" (2024–26) to **"Amplify" (2027+)**; the £100m cost programme lands by 2027 (sections 2 and 7).	That you know the firm is at a turning point: you'd join in Sept 2027, the first year of Amplify.
"Delivering positive client outcomes"	Consumer Duty is the FCA's lens (section 3).	Use the words "client outcomes" and "fair value" naturally. They're SJP's current vocabulary for a reason.
"Comfortable working with data … presenting findings clearly" / "reports for senior leaders"		Your own evidence: a dataset you analysed, a recommendation you made, a presentation you gave.

Likely video interview questions and the angle for each

These are angles, not scripts. A strong answer needs your own examples (degree, work, societies).

1. **"Why St James's Place?"**
    - **Angle:** SJP is the UK's largest advice business, with ~5,000 Partners and over a million clients.
    - **Angle:** it's at an inflection point. The charging change is done and the Amplify phase starts the year you'd join.
    - **Angle:** a head-office role here shapes how advice is delivered at scale.
    - **Avoid:** generic "prestigious firm" lines.
2. **"Why this programme rather than becoming an adviser / going into asset management?"**
    - **Angle:** you're interested in the *system* behind advice: proposition, data, strategy.
    - **Angle:** the rotations give breadth, and the Level 4 gives technical depth.
    - **Angle:** your asset-management fee knowledge is useful context, but you want to be closer to the client journey.
3. **"What do you know about our business?"**
    - **Angle:** the Partnership; vertical integration (advice, product, funds).
    - **Angle:** the simple, comparable charging structure from August 2025.
    - **Angle:** record FUM (~£240bn); 95% retention.
    - Keep it to three facts and one insight (e.g. the gross vs net flow point).
4. **"What challenges or opportunities face SJP / the industry?"**
    - **Opportunities:** the advice gap; pensions in IHT from 2027; ageing wealth.
    - **Challenges:** AI and targeted support at the lower end; competition from platforms (Quilter, AJ Bell); keeping the best Partners.
    - **Don't skip the regulatory angle:** Consumer Duty and evidencing value. Mention the OSE review factually and briefly (see "avoid" #4 below).
5. **"Tell us about a time you used data to solve a problem / influenced a decision."**
    - Structure the answer as STAR (Situation, Task, Action, Result).
    - Quantify the result.
    - Mirror the JD: "insight", "decision-making", "presented to".
6. **"Tell us about managing competing priorities / adapting to change."**
    - This maps directly to the JD's "fast-paced" and "adaptability".
    - The rotation structure means you'll change teams every few months, so show you thrive on that.
7. **"How would you explain [a financial concept] to a client?"** For example, why advice costs what it does, or what an ISA is.
    - **Angle:** plain English, no jargon. That's how they test the "communication" requirement.

Practical points

- **The closing date (16 Oct 2026) has passed.** Your invite came on 4 Nov, so you're through the CV screen. Check the email for the deadline to complete the video interview.
- **Right to work:** the programme can't sponsor visas. You're presumably fine, but be ready to confirm it.
- **Logistics:** London, Lombard Street; hybrid with at least three office days a week; occasional UK travel. If asked, show you're comfortable with that.

Five things to say in an interview

1. **"SJP's real asset is its distribution: about 5,000 advisers and roughly 95% client retention. The products sit behind that."** This shows you understand that the moat is the Partnership and the relationship, not fund performance.
2. **"The 2025 charging change swapped higher short-term margin for cleaner, comparable pricing. New business is profitable from day one, and the six-year gestation book unwinds over time, which is why management expects earnings to accelerate from 2027."** This shows you understand the mechanics, not just the headline.
3. **"Consumer Duty moved the standard from 'was it disclosed?' to 'is it fair value, and can you evidence it?'. That's what exposed charging for annual reviews that weren't delivered. It's an industry-wide issue, but SJP was the biggest and went first."** This is balanced, accurate and shows regulatory awareness.
4. **"The number I'd watch is net inflows as a percentage of opening FUM. Gross inflows are strong, but with 95% retention SJP has to raise about £11bn a year just to stand still."** This shows commercial and analytical maturity.
5. **"The structural tailwinds for advice are real: pension freedoms, frozen thresholds, and pensions coming into inheritance tax from 2027. SJP is now entering its 'Amplify' phase, and a lot of that depends on making ~5,000 Partners more productive. That's the work the Wealth Management function does, and it's what I'd want to contribute to."** This links the firm's strategy to the actual role (see section 8). Check the IHT timing again before saying it.

Five things to avoid saying, and why

1. **"SJP is a private bank" or "SJP serves ultra-high-net-worth clients."** It doesn't. The average client has about £226k with SJP, and the model is mass-affluent to HNW advice. Saying this shows you haven't done the basics.
2. **"The FCA fined SJP £426m."** False. The £426m was SJP's own *provision* for refunds, much of which has since been released. I found no FCA fine on this. Precision on this point is a credibility test.
3. **"SJP's advisers are independent."** They are **restricted**. Getting this wrong suggests you don't understand UK advice regulation or SJP's model.
4. **Dismissing the controversy ("that's all in the past") or dwelling on it.** Interviewers expect you to know about it. The strong answer acknowledges it, explains what changed (charges, EWC, review), and points to what's still being worked through. Either extreme reads badly.
5. **Quoting precise contested numbers** such as the exact AI sell-off percentage, a precise adviser headcount, today's share price, or "£430m". Sources conflict on these. Use ranges or SJP's own figures. One wrong precise number costs more than an accurate approximation.

Sources

SJP primary

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- AJ Bell year-end trading update, 22 Oct 2026 (PDF)
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- Burges Salmon: targeted support goes live 6 April 2026

Not accessed directly: the FT, Citywire and Financial News are paywalled. Where they are cited, it is via other outlets' reporting of them. The FCA's ongoing-advice review findings were only seen second-hand, so read them on fca.org.uk before quoting specific percentages.